AUWA Brand Guidelines

Created: April 2026. The working brand reference for all AUWA touchpoints. Load when working on visual design, social content, brand decisions, or any new touchpoint.

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1. Brand Essence

AUWA (あうわ) — "the harmony between the unseen and the seen." The brand makes the invisible visible: invisible emotions (app), invisible craftsmanship (store), invisible kokoro within all living things (stories).

The brand feels like: a quiet room in a Japanese temple at dusk. Dark, warm, still. Then light enters.

Brand reference points:

- **Aesop** — Luxury minimalism, craft-forward. Dark interiors, serif type, every store feels like the same calm room. The gold standard for "premium through restraint." AUWA's app and social should feel like walking into an Aesop store: you immediately know someone cared about every detail.
- **Kinfolk** — Editorial calm, intentional living. Wide-tracked serif wordmark. Generous white space. Photography that breathes. The confidence to leave half the page empty. AUWA's typography and spacing should carry this same unhurried authority.
- **Cereal** — Refined design magazine. Restrained colour palette, serif headlines, atmospheric travel photography. The exact intersection of design culture and wanderlust that AUWA's audience inhabits.
- **Hoshinoya** — Japanese luxury hospitality. Dark, warm, nature-integrated. Space as design. Shows how Japanese premium doesn't need to be austere — it can be warm and inviting while remaining minimal. AUWA's dark palette should feel this way: enveloping, not cold.
- **Studio Ghibli** — Warmth beneath simplicity. Hand-drawn worlds that adults take as seriously as children. The precedent for illustrated content that bypasses cynicism. AUWA's illustration integration follows this path.
- **Aman Resorts** — "Less is more" luxury. No logos on the building. The brand exists in the experience, not the signage. AUWA should feel like this: the brand recedes, the experience

comes forward.

- **Monocle** — Tyler Brûlé's editorial worldview extended into products, retail, and radio. One coherent taste level across every touchpoint. Serif masthead, clean layouts. Proves that editorial authority translates into commerce.
- **Mubi** — Film streaming platform with a dark, cinematic UI. Serif display type over moody imagery. Proves that dark interfaces with serif typography can feel premium and inviting for a digital product.

What AUWA is not: Headspace-style illustration pop. Wellness-brand pastels. Busy Japanese maximalism. Tech-startup energy. Anything with a gradient that screams "app."

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2. Logo

The Wordmark

The AUWA logo is the wordmark itself — the letters A-U-W-A set in Cormorant Light with wide tracking. No separate symbol, no icon, no monogram. The word is the logo.

The wordmark works because:

- The natural symmetry of A-U-W-A mirrors itself (the two A's as bookends, U-W as the centre)
- This symmetry echoes the etymology: あ (heavens) and わ (earth) framing う (connection)
- Serif letterforms carry signals of craft, history, and intention — the right signals for a Japanese philosophy brand
- It scales cleanly from social profile to website header to printed materials

Wordmark specifications:

- **Typeface:** Cormorant Light (300 weight)
- **Case:** All uppercase
- **Letter-spacing:** 0.25em (established in teaser page header)
- **Colour:** cosmic-200 (oklch 0.87 0.012 250) on dark backgrounds; void (oklch 0.08 0.025 250) on light backgrounds

Minimum clear space: The height of the letter "U" on all sides.

Usage:

- The wordmark appears in the header across all sections of auwa.life
- Always set in Cormorant Light, never redrawn or substituted
- Never placed over busy imagery — always over solid dark or solid light backgrounds
- Never distorted, outlined, shadowed, or animated (the orb animates; the wordmark is still)

Social Profile Image

The wordmark at social icon scale (110x110px display). Two options to test:

Option A: The full "AUWA" wordmark centred in a dark circle (void background). Works if the tracking is tight enough to read at small sizes.

Option B: A single "A" in Cormorant Light, centred in a dark circle. Cleaner at icon scale, still recognisably the brand.

Test both at actual Instagram/LinkedIn display sizes before deciding. The character is never the profile image — it lives inside the experience, not on the business layer.

What About a Custom Logo Later?

If the brand grows to the point where a bespoke mark would add value (physical packaging, figure authentication stamps, embossed on store products), explore a custom-drawn version of the wordmark — refined letterforms with subtle ligatures or a harmonised U-W connection. This is a Year 2 investment, not a launch requirement. The Cormorant wordmark is strong enough to launch with.

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3. Typography

The Decision: Serif Selection

Cormorant is the current serif, established during the teaser page build. It's elegant and ancient-feeling, but at display sizes it can feel thin compared to brands like Kinfolk whose serif carries more weight and presence. Before locking the final typeface, test these alternatives side by side — set "AUWA" as a wordmark and "Japanese philosophy for the age of AI" as a headline in each, at desktop scale, on the void background:

Google Fonts (free, already compatible with Next.js):

Font	Character	Best For	Consideration
Cormorant (current)	Ancient, delicate, refined	Reflection text, elegant body	Can feel thin at large display sizes; needs larger sizing or heavier weight for headlines
EB Garamond	Classic, scholarly, deep history	Wordmark, editorial text	More readable than Cormorant at body sizes; Claude Garamond's original — carries real historical weight
Playfair Display	High contrast, editorial, confident	Headlines, wordmark	More presence than Cormorant at large sizes; Kinfolk-adjacent feel. Risk: can feel too "magazine editorial"
DM Serif Display	Clean, impactful, modern serif	Headlines, wordmark	Strongest presence at display sizes; only comes in Regular weight
Spectral	Screen-optimised, clear, warm	Body serif, reflections	Designed specifically for digital; clean at small sizes
Crimson Pro	Warm, readable, versatile	Body serif, longer text	Excellent across all sizes; the most "book-like" option
Newsreader	Contemporary editorial, slightly sharp	Headlines, editorial	Designed for digital reading; has optical sizes built in
Fraunces	Soft, organic, slightly quirky	Display only	Variable font with "WONK" axis — can dial in personality. More playful than the others

Premium foundry fonts (if you want to invest £50-200 in a licence):

Font	Foundry	Why It's Worth Considering
Canela	Commercial Type	The luxury brand serif. Used by Apple, Glossier, many premium brands. Warm, elegant, confident at every size.
Tiempos	Klim Type Foundry	Used by NYT, Financial Times, Kinfolk. The serious editorial serif. If AUWA wants Kinfolk-level typographic authority, this is the direct route.
GT Sectra	Grilli Type	Sharp, precise, slightly contemporary. Used by many design-forward brands.
Domaine	Klim	Elegant, versatile, works at display and text sizes.

Freight Display	GarageFonts	Warm, editorial, beautiful at large sizes. Used by many premium publishers.

Recommendation: Test Cormorant, EB Garamond, Playfair Display, and DM Serif Display side by side in Figma. These four cover the spectrum from delicate (Cormorant) to confident (DM Serif Display). If none feel right, Canela or Tiempos are worth the licence cost — they're the typefaces AUWA's reference brands actually use. Whichever you choose, the principles below (hierarchy, tracking, sizing) stay the same.

Sizing note: The current teaser headline (Cormorant Light at ~48-60px) feels a touch undersized compared to Kinfolk's confident presence. For the final brand, consider either: (a) increasing hero headline size to 72-96px desktop, or (b) stepping up to Cormorant Regular (400) weight for headlines while keeping Light (300) for the wordmark. The wordmark tracking (0.25em) is right — it's the headline sizing that needs more confidence.

Primary Serif (Display + Editorial)

The voice of AUWA. Used for all brand-level, emotional, and editorial text. Currently Cormorant — may change after testing above.

- **Light/300:** Wordmark, AI reflection text, quote overlays on social
- **Regular/400:** Hero headlines, subheadlines, brand copy, about pages
- **Medium/500:** Occasional emphasis (sparingly)

Secondary: Instrument Sans (Functional Sans-Serif)

The working typeface. Used for all UI and functional elements. This stays regardless of serif choice.

- **Regular (400):** Body text, navigation, form labels, metadata, captions
- **Medium (500):** Buttons, small caps navigation (as in teaser header)
- **SemiBold (600):** Strong emphasis where needed (sparingly)

Clean, modern, slightly warm. Doesn't compete with the serif — it disappears into the background, letting the serif do the emotional work.

Japanese: Noto Sans JP

For Japanese text (micro-season names, kanji, Rieko's Japanese copy). Light (300) and Regular (400) weights only. Consider also testing **Noto Serif JP** for editorial Japanese text (paired with

whichever Latin serif you choose).

Type Hierarchy (For Reference)

Element	Typeface	Weight	Size (Mobile)	Size (Desktop)	Tracking
Wordmark / Logo	Serif	Light	20px	24px	0.25em
Hero Headline	Serif	Regular	40px	72-96px	0.02-0.04em
Subtitle	Serif	Light	18px	22px	0.04em
AI Reflection Text	Serif	Regular	18px	22px	0.02em
Body Copy	Instrument Sans	400	15px	16px	0
Navigation	Instrument Sans	500	12px	13px	0.12em (uppercase)
Caption / Meta	Instrument Sans	400	12px	13px	0.02em
Japanese Text	Noto Sans JP	300	14px	16px	0

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4. Colour System

The Principle

AUWA lives in darkness. Light comes from within — from the kokoro being revealed. The brand's default state is dark and quiet. Colour enters through gradients, glows, and the Yamato emotional states. This mirrors the app experience: you arrive in darkness, and AUWA's light shower reveals your kokoro in colour.

Foundation Palette (Established in Teaser)

```
Void (background):        oklch(0.08  0.025  250)
Cosmic 900:               oklch(0.13  0.030  250)
```

```
Cosmic 800:                oklch(0.18  0.028  250)
Cosmic 700:                oklch(0.25  0.025  250)
Cosmic 600:                oklch(0.35  0.022  250)
Cosmic 500:                oklch(0.45  0.020  250)  — secondary text
Cosmic 400:                oklch(0.60  0.018  250)  — subtle text
Cosmic 300:                oklch(0.75  0.015  250)
Cosmic 200:                oklch(0.87  0.012  250)  — primary text
Cosmic 100:                oklch(0.93  0.008  250)
Cosmic 50:                 oklch(0.97  0.005  250)  — bright text
Glow:                      oklch(0.85  0.15   105)  — orb, accents
Glow Dim:                  oklch(0.70  0.10   105)  — hover states
```

These are cool-toned, deep, slightly purple-blue darks. Not pure black — there's always a hint of cosmic depth.

Yamato Emotional State Colours (5 Gradient Families)

```
Hare (  /Radiant):     oklch(0.82  0.14  85)   — warm gold/amber
Takaburi (  /Intense):  oklch(0.60  0.18  25)   — deep crimson/rust
Aware (  /Reflective):  oklch(0.70  0.06  250)  — cool blue/indigo
Yuragi (  /Unsettled):  oklch(0.65  0.12  55)   — amber/ochre
Nagomi (  /Serene):      oklch(0.75  0.10  160)  — soft sage/green
```

These are the starting points for the 5 gradient families used in the app's kokoro revelation screens and across social content. Each emotional state has a 3-4 stop gradient to be developed in Figma:

- **Hare (Radiant):** Gold → amber → soft peach (warm, expanding, light)
- **Takaburi (Intense):** Crimson → burnt orange → dark rust (intense, rising, hot)
- **Aware (Reflective):** Indigo → steel blue → soft grey-blue (cool, receding, still)
- **Yuragi (Unsettled):** Amber → ochre → muted bronze (shifting, restless, warm-cool tension)
- **Nagomi (Serene):** Sage → warm olive → soft earth (grounded, open, calm)

Light Backgrounds

For contexts requiring light backgrounds (printed materials, some store product pages, accessibility alternatives):

- Background: cosmic-50 (oklch 0.97 0.005 250) — not pure white, slightly warm

- Text: void or cosmic-900
- Wordmark: void
- Accents: emotion colours at reduced opacity

The light palette is secondary. Dark-first is the brand's natural state.

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5. The Orb

The glowing orb is AUWA's presence before the character appears. It pulses gently, breathes, and transforms during the light shower. On the teaser page it sits at the centre of the screen as the primary visual element.

Usage:

- Teaser pages: hero element
- App: the input screen's visual anchor, transforms into the light shower
- Website backgrounds: very subtle, atmospheric (never dominant outside the app)
- Social: sparingly — the orb belongs to the digital experience, not print/static contexts

Never: place the orb next to the wordmark as a combined logo. They serve different purposes.

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6. Photography Direction

Tom's Japan photography catalogue (17M+ Unsplash views) is the primary photography asset. The style that works for AUWA:

What to use

- **Atmospheric landscapes:** Temples at dawn, misty mountains, bamboo groves, seasonal transitions. The images that got 8M+ views on Unsplash are exactly the right tone.
- **Quiet moments:** A path through trees, rain on stone, light through paper screens, a single flower. Ma (間) — space and silence.
- **Craftsmanship (for store):** Hands at work, close-ups of texture, the process of making. From the Monolise research trip photography.

- **Seasonal rhythm:** Cherry blossom, autumn maple, snow on stone, summer light. Content that refreshes with the 72 micro-seasons.

What to avoid

- Tourist-perspective shots (crowds, selfies, busy intersections)
- Overly saturated or HDR-processed images
- Food photography unless atmospheric (a bowl of matcha in morning light, yes; a plate of sushi with garnish detail, no)
- Anything that feels like a stock photo or travel blog

Treatment

- **Muted, slightly desaturated.** Bring warmth but pull back saturation. The palette should feel like it lives in the same world as the OKLCH cosmic colours.
- **Subtle grain/noise.** A light film grain texture (2-4% noise) prevents images feeling too digital and adds warmth. This is the bridge between Rieko's illustration dreaminess and the photographic content.
- **Gentle vignette.** Dark edges draw the eye inward and maintain the "light emerging from darkness" principle.
- **Consistent warmth.** All photography should lean warm — not orange, but the warmth of late afternoon light rather than clinical daylight.

Create a Lightroom preset that standardises this treatment so all photography content shares the same feel regardless of when or where it was shot.

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7. Illustration Integration

Rieko's illustrations are AUWA's most valuable asset. They need to coexist with photography and typography without the brand feeling like it has two visual languages fighting each other.

The Bridge

The bridge between photography and illustration is **colour and atmosphere.** Both should feel like they exist in the same world:

- Photography: muted, warm, slightly dreamy (grain, vignette, desaturation)

- Illustration: warm, textured, slightly muted (not full-saturation children's book colour)
- Both sit on the same dark backgrounds with the same cosmic colour system

Social Content Integration

When illustration and photography appear in the same feed, the unifying elements are:

- **Consistent dark background** (void or cosmic-900) framing every post
- **Consistent typography** (Cormorant for all quote/text overlays, same sizing and tracking)
- **Consistent colour temperature** (warm, never cold or clinical)
- **Consistent border/framing** (if using borders — same weight, same colour, same radius across all post types)

Post Types by Content

Content Type	Visual Source	Frame/Treatment
Kokoro Reveal	Illustration + type	Dark bg, character centred, Cormorant quote below/overlay, emotion gradient accent
Japanese Wisdom	Typography-led	Dark bg, Cormorant display text, subtle illustration or gradient accent element
Behind the Kokoro	Photography (process)	Dark bg frame, photo muted/warm, Instrument Sans caption
Seasonal Living	Photography (Japan)	Dark bg frame, photo muted/warm, optional Cormorant text overlay
The constant across all four pillars: **dark frame, warm content, Cormorant voice, space.**		

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8. Social Content Templates

The Grid Principle

The Instagram grid should feel like opening a book of quiet, beautiful pages — not a mosaic of competing styles. When someone visits @auwa.life and sees the 3x3 grid, every thumbnail should feel like it belongs in the same room.

This means:

- **Consistent aspect ratio:** 4:5 (1080x1350) for all feed posts (maximum screen real estate, consistent grid)
- **Consistent outer frame:** Every post sits on the void background with generous padding (minimum 60px equivalent on each side). The dark frame is the unifying element.
- **Consistent text placement:** All typography aligns to the same invisible grid within the frame
- **Colour restraint:** No more than one accent colour per post (from the emotion palette or glow)

Template 1: Quote Card (Kokoro Reveal / Japanese Wisdom)

- 1080 x 1350px, void background
- Cormorant Light centred text (28-36px for headline, 16-18px for attribution)
- Optional: subtle gradient wash behind text (one emotion colour at 10-15% opacity)
- Optional: small AUWA character illustration at bottom (thumbnail scale, atmospheric)
- Wordmark "AUWA" bottom-centre, small, cosmic-500

Template 2: Photography (Seasonal Living / Behind the Kokoro)

- 1080 x 1350px, void background with photo inset (leaving ~40-60px dark border on all sides)
- Photo treated: warm, desaturated, grain
- Optional: Cormorant text overlay (short, positioned lower third)
- Wordmark "AUWA" bottom-centre, small

Template 3: Illustration (Kokoro Reveal / Behind the Kokoro)

- 1080 x 1350px, void background
- Illustration centred or offset, breathing room around it
- Cormorant text if paired with a reflection or quote
- Wordmark "AUWA" bottom-centre, small

Template 4: Carousel Slide (Japanese Wisdom)

- 1080 x 1350px, void background
- Slide 1: Cormorant headline (the hook)
- Slides 2-6: Instrument Sans body text with generous spacing, one idea per slide
- Final slide: call-to-action or wordmark
- Consistent padding, font sizes, and colour across all slides

Reel Cover Image

- 1080 x 1920px (9:16), but design the central 1080 x 1350px area for feed grid crop
- Cormorant text centred in the safe zone
- Void background or atmospheric photography (muted)

Story Template

- 1080 x 1920px
- Void background
- Cormorant text for quotes/reflections
- Instrument Sans for interactive elements (polls, questions)
- AUWA wordmark top-left (small, consistent placement)

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9. Motion & Animation

Principles

- **Slow and deliberate.** AUWA doesn't rush. Animations use ease-out-expo (cubic-bezier 0.16, 1, 0.3, 1) — fast departure, gentle arrival. Like a breath out.
- **Fade, don't slide.** Elements appear by fading in and gently scaling, not sliding in from edges. The app already uses this approach (Framer Motion fade-in components).
- **The light shower is the hero animation.** All other motion is supporting — subtle, ambient, never competing.

For Social (Reels / Runway)

- Slow, atmospheric. Think 0.5-1 second transitions between elements.
- Rieko's illustrations can have subtle parallax (foreground/background layers moving at different speeds) or gentle breathing motion (Runway's motion tools)

- Text reveals: fade in word by word or line by line, Cormorant, centred, against void
- Never: fast cuts, beat-synced transitions, zoom-punch effects, or anything that feels like a TikTok trend

Audio

- Ambient, atmospheric, warm. Suno-generated tones that feel like the inside of a temple.
- No beats, no vocals, no commercial music
- The existing ambient.mp3 on the teaser page sets the reference tone

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10. Across the Four Sections

All sections live under a single domain: **auwa.life** with subpaths. auwalife.com mirrors to auwa.life for the Japan market. Social handles: @auwa.life (Instagram, TikTok, YouTube), @auwa_life (X), @Auwa (LinkedIn).

/app (Kokoro Mirror)

Dark-first. Minimal chrome during the experience. Cormorant for AUWA's voice, Instrument Sans for UI. The revelation screen is the hero — everything else supports getting there and reflecting afterward.

/store (Craftsman Marketplace)

Slightly lighter touch — product pages may use light backgrounds for product photography clarity, but the overall framing and navigation stays dark. Cormorant for editorial (craftsman stories, product descriptions), Instrument Sans for functional (pricing, specs, cart). Products shot on white backgrounds (AI-standardised) sit within the dark AUWA frame. Note: Shopify integration may require headless Storefront API or subdomain proxy (store.auwa.life) to maintain the /store subpath — technical decision to make during build.

/journal (Editorial)

Dark-first. Editorial feel — more text, more space, more story. Photography-led. Cormorant-heavy for headlines, Instrument Sans for body. Long-form articles, craftsman profiles, travel essays. This is where the brand breathes most fully and where SEO value accumulates.

/book (Illustrated Stories)

Dark-first. The illustrated stories and the AUWA universe origin. Cormorant-heavy. Illustration and animation-forward. The most immersive, atmospheric section.

Shared Elements

- Same header: wordmark left, navigation right (links adapt per section)
- Same footer: minimal, wordmark, copyright, email
- Same font stack: Cormorant + Instrument Sans + Noto Sans JP
- Same colour system: void/cosmic palette + Yamato emotional states
- Same animation easing: ease-out-expo
- Single Next.js codebase serving all sections

The four sections should feel like four rooms in the same building, not four separate buildings.

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11. Brand Book Workflow

The Approach: Living System, Not Static Book

The Gritt-style Figma brand book (30+ pages of static frames) is the right deliverable for a client who needs to hand off their brand to a team of people. AUWA has two people. The brand needs to be a living system that evolves as you build, not a monument you create once and never update.

The brand lives in three places:

1. **This document** (`context/brand.md`) — The written rules. Every Claude Code session reads this and applies it. When you change a decision (e.g. swap Cormorant for Canela), you update one file and every future session inherits it. This is the source of truth for *decisions*.

2. **Figma** — The visual reference. A single Figma file (not a 30-page deck) with these frames:

    - **Typography specimen** — The chosen serif at key sizes (wordmark, headline, body, reflection text) on both dark and light backgrounds. Side by side with Instrument Sans.

- **Colour swatches** — Void/cosmic palette + 5 Yamato emotional state gradient families. OKLCH values labelled.
- **Wordmark lockups** — Dark bg, light bg, social icon versions (both "AUWA" and "A" options).
- **Social templates** — The 4 template types (quote, photography, illustration, carousel) as duplicatable frames.
- **Photography treatment** — 3-4 example photos with the Lightroom-style treatment applied, before/after.
- **Illustration integration** — 2-3 examples showing Rieko's illustrations within the social templates and on the void background.
- **Component library** — Buttons, input fields, cards, navigation — the Tailwind components as Figma components.

This is ~8-12 frames, not 30+. It's a visual reference you and Rieko review together and share with future collaborators if needed. It evolves as the brand evolves — you add frames, not rewrite a book.

3. **Code** (`globals.css` + Tailwind config) — The implementation. The OKLCH colour system, font stack, and spacing are already defined in the teaser page's CSS. When you build the app and the other sites, this CSS is the single source of truth for *values*. Figma and code stay in sync — if you change a colour in Figma, update the CSS variable. If you change it in code, update the Figma swatch.

Steps to Create

Step 1: Font Decision (1-2 hours, Figma) Create a single Figma frame. Set "AUWA" as a wordmark and "Japanese philosophy for the age of AI" as a headline in each candidate serif (Cormorant, EB Garamond, Playfair Display, DM Serif Display — plus Canela/Tiempos if you want to test premium). Same void background. Same sizing. Same tracking. Show Rieko. Pick one. Update this document and the code.

Step 2: Template Creation (2-3 hours, Figma) Build the 4 social content templates as Figma components with auto-layout. Use the chosen serif, the OKLCH colours (Figma supports OKLCH in the latest versions), and the void background. Make them duplicatable so Rieko can drop in illustrations or Tom can drop in photography and export directly. These become the production templates for all Instagram content.

Step 3: Photography Preset (30 minutes, Lightroom) Take 5 Japan photos from Tom's catalogue, apply the treatment described in Section 6 (desaturate, warm, grain, vignette). Save as a Lightroom preset called "AUWA — Atmospheric." Apply to all future photography content.

Step 4: Test Grid (1 hour, Figma) Lay out a 3x3 Instagram grid using the templates: mix of quote cards, photography, and illustration. Does it feel like one coherent world? If any post feels like it's from a different brand, adjust the template. This is the visual gut-check before you start posting.

Step 5: Visual Brand Reference (1 hour, Figma) Arrange the typography specimen, colour swatches, wordmark lockups, and example content into a clean presentation layout. This is your "brand book" — lightweight, visual, shareable. Export as PDF if needed for partners/press.

Total time: ~6-8 hours. Compare that to a traditional 30+ page static brand book (40-60 hours). And this version updates in 5 minutes when you change a decision.

For External Partners (Future)

When you eventually need to share brand guidelines externally (craftsman partners, Fin DAC, press kit), export the Figma visual reference as a PDF and pair it with a one-page summary extracted from this document. You don't need a separate "client-facing" brand book — the visual reference IS the brand book. The written rules here give Claude Code (and you) the working detail that a PDF can't.

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12. What This Document Is

A working reference that evolves as AUWA evolves. Not a monument. The decisions above are enough to build all four sections of auwa.life, create months of coherent Instagram content, and brief any future collaborator.

When something isn't covered here, apply two principles: **would this feel at home in the quiet room?** and **does this let the content speak, or does it compete with it?**

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